A Mizo Minefield

Why did PM Narendra Modi cancel his October 30 visit to Mamit in Mizoram? The political bazaar was sizzling with speculation, and naturally so. It's a delicate point on which the Opposition lost no time to rush in with its rapier-like sarcasm. Congress's Jairam Ramesh was not one to let go of the opportunity to say the PM felt embarrassed to campaign in the state as he had found no time to visit neighbouring Manipur, which has witnessed ethnic violence since May. Others piled on more nuance, saying it was because CM Zoramthanga had refused to share a stage with the PM. In an interview, Zoramthanga had indeed alluded to the ongoing conflict in BJP-ruled Manipur, and said it'd not be good for his party, the Mizo National Front, to "show sympathy towards the BJP". Mizos, who are overwhelmingly Christian, did not like what happened in the neighbouring state—where plenty of churches were burned down in the violence. "It'll be better if the prime minister comes alone and he shares the platform by himself, and I take the stage separately by myself," said the CM. Ironically, Zoramthanga's MNF is a part of the BJP-led Northeast Democratic Alliance (NEDA) and an NDA ally at the Centre. But it does not work with the BJP in Mizoram. Either way, Manipur has become a poll issue in Mizoram. And Zoramthanga has defeated George W. Bush's dictum by being both "with" and "against" all at once. ■





DISHOOM DISHOOM DEMOCRAZY

From duel to *dangal*, electoral contests are the time when metaphors relating to physical combat fly around everywhere. But of course, whether we resort to fancy knightly imagery or more homespun ones, it's all only figurative, isn't it? No one gets a cartoonish dark eye or a bloody nose in real life. Or so we thought. What we have today—the TV channel debate—is the near-equivalent of the old barroom in the Wild West. A place with blood in the air, where a brawl is an inevitability waiting to happen. Well, it happened that night. Live. The combatants? On one side, Kuna Srisailam Goud, a grizzled old gunfighter from those parts, who was elected as Quthbullapur MLA during the united Andhra days first as an

EXTRA DRY COCKTAILS

Our cops doing a desi version of the prohibitory Saudi Arabian mutawa is a natural occurrence during poll season—surveillance posses stand vigil at random points to check for the flow of booze, besides of course cash bundles, weaponry and other goodies that can be used to lure or coerce voters. But it's having comical effects in Madhya Pradesh. The state jewellers association screamed 'harassment' after the Nagod police seized gold ornaments worth crores from bonafide *johris* during a vehicle check. And if Rajasthan managed to have its elections deferred to

Illustrations by SIDDHANT JUMDE